LIVES

GUN/THE ALMIGHTY
Leeds Duchess Of York

CRITICS OF what can loosely be termed rock music would have had a field day with The Almighty.

From the opening 'Resurrection Mother', theirs was a set of age-old clichés – and any preconceived notions of machismo, seriousness and a void where humour should live would have been immovably reinforced.

On the positive side, they conjure a healthy mix of potent riffs and ferocious rhythms that maintain even the most disaffected listener's attention – though titles as ludicrous as 'Full Force Loving Machine' can only work if injected with a modicum of irony.

Gun are here to entertain, and you can be damned sure they'll extract a little pleasure for themselves in the meantime.

Their songs often start slowly, Mark Rankin's voice being barely a whisper, ascending gradually through guitar avalanches and soaring vocals to finish in a magnificent crescendo. 'Better Days' (the single) and 'Shame On You' demonstrate these qualities to the full, while 'Coming Home' employs a fragile harmonica with a gushing melody.

The album's title track, 'Taking On The World', is moody, anthemic and awash with intensity. And, blow me, if they don't allow themselves the luxury of covering Thin Lizzy's 'Don't Believe A Word'. If bands are performing Gun songs with equal passion in 15 years time, it would be no surprise.

IAN CHEEK

JAMES
Liverpool Royal Court

THERE'S A feeling of completeness with James these days.

Whereas the original quartet relied largely on bruising rhythms and frenetic, skittery guitars to underpin Tim Booth's vocal whooping, this expanded six-piece have set about sculpting a sublime, integral set of hymns from their village.

On this, the first date of the current tour, the band already have their sights fixed firmly on Nirvana. The first half grabs eagerly at its coat tails, with newer material as well as confirmed favourites – such as 'Scarecrow' and 'Johnny Yen' – vying for attention.

The new single, 'Sit Down', bounds along in seven-league boots, proving the quirkiness of yore to be still happily intact. Only now it's harnessed and fully focused, with Mark Hunter's ivories and Saul Davies' violin providing essential swathes of colour, allowing these taut anthems to breathe.

But momentum slips temporarily, and for 20 minutes James are ungainly and vulnerable. 'Whoops' attempts to stem the tide, its gargantuan beat unleashed like a Rottweiler on heat, and colliding head on with Larry Gott's scorching slide guitar. 'Riders' and the closing 'Folklore', though, collapse beneath their own tremors. Booth's plea on the former, "*I don't want that poison in. . .*", proves ultimately useless – it's already there.

Thankfully, the three encores restore a heady euphoria. 'What For' rouses the crowd to fever pitch, which culminates with 'Stutter''s chilling paranoia.

Throughout, Tim Booth lurches and contorts like an eerie puppet, whose master has just unearthed the dubious delights of Ecstasy.

But the strings are nowhere to be seen, for James have shrugged off the unfortunate shackles of their major deal and are contenders once more.

TIM PEACOCK

SCAREHUNTERS
Islington The Cave

SEEING A band at The Cave is the gig equivalent of *Bullseye*.

Within the venue's tacky confines you can see the latest aspirants to the rock 'n' roll throne *and* take home "a video of your favourite band for only ten quid"– shot in fabulous Technicolor by a cameraman who looks remarkably like the bouncer.

Tonight, The Scarehunters have travelled from Nottingham for the experience and, despite the Jim Bowen introduction, launch into their gabba-gabba-hey opening song 'Snakecharmer'.

Though another Poppies/Jesus Jones inflection on the white-boys-use-cut-up-dance-formula, The Scarehunters have developed their own version of Glitter Band rhythms. Over these their gangly frontman raps, and squeezes wailing tunes from the neck of his guitar.

'Save Your Soul' sounds joyously like the Colourbox 'World Cup Theme' and sends him careering across the stage doing a Chuck Berry duck walk, while 'Send Me All Your Money' could be a message to buy the 'fave vid'.

As the two flanking guitarists hit the mikes for yet another hey-hey-hey chant, it starts to get repetitive but The Scarehunters know they're here to get us sweating, and that's what they mean to do.

They finish with 'You're Upset', sarcastically dedicated to London yuppies and definitely one up for the Nottingham scuzzbags.

As for that ten quid video? Well, it's not quite time to trade in your '70s 'Glam Rock' compilation.

ROCKFORD

DAWN AFTER DARK
Shepherds Bush Opera On The Green

THE SADDEST thing about Dawn After Dark is that despite having plied their trade for longer than The Cult, comparisons seem inevitable.

There is one major difference – DAD's joyful grunge workouts come straight from the heart, all unwashed hair and encompassing headbands.

They open with 'Crystal High', a dramatic rush of hammy psychedelia with no traces of po-faced posturing.

Indeed, throughout such blistering cracks as 'Wild Wild Love' and 'Dead On Time', singer H and his band of scuzzbags' dedication to foaming, sweating inhibition goes down far better than a lecture in a fake American accent ever could.

They climax with the new single, 'Maximum Overdrive', a demented, screeching anthem delivered with the appropriate gusto.

Dawn After Dark may not be future messiahs but neither are they fashion victim rock. Awlright?

CATHI UNSWORTH

Cool for Cats

YO LA TENGO/THE TELESCOPES/THE CATERAN
Highbury Corner T&C 2

THE CATERAN's scrawny noise pushes our mental energy until we can take no more.

"*Don't want no more*", they scream – although with the aural blurring qualities of their viscous guitar thrash it could've been almost anything. Was it about the Poll Tax? The 1992 Euro-alignment? Who knows. Like everything else, bar the wonderful 'Kitty Kitten', it's gratuitously ambiguous.

The new LP, 'Ache', is the epitome of The Cateran's essence. Their music is one gigantic headstrong surge of pain, a hair swilling, posture pulling force of noise that's ably backed up by some of the most impetuous drumming since Swans' Roli Mosiman.

Like The Cateran's apt album title, The Telescopes' very name defines them. Their music is the product of an inspired tunnel vision gazing backwards over the last 20 years of rock alienation.

Singer Steve has swallowed whole the Mary Chain's melancholy stage presence – the devotional lack of eye contact, the vacant audience rapport – and matched it with an attitude that says, Danger emotionally flayed youth at work.

The music's tempestuous stuff, each song a fossilised remnant of a previous teen crush. The opener, 'There Is No Floor' is the Mary Chain's 'Upside Down' without happy feedback, while 'Suffocation' is the dislocated jangling of The Birthday Party's 'Mr Clarinet'.

Only Yo La Tengo could surpass them and, paradoxically, only because they have so *much* to offer. Their recent album, 'President Yo La Tengo', suggests they can blend the husky tones of Reed (Lou not Jim) with The Miracle Legion's sense of tranquility. Tonight, though, they, er, suck.

One song exists in a oxygen tent filled with a stagnant, stomach turning bass belch, while drummer Georgia Hubley's horsey vocals are lost behind Ira Kaplan's Dylanesque rambling.

It's apologetic, too close to the real thing and too rooted in the treadmill of folkland's guitar myth to offer any salvation. So that while Yo's 'Drug Test' – with its "*I wish I was high*" lyric – is suitably apathetic, it is far less attractive than anything by those masters of apathy, Dinosaur Jr.

Three revisions of the past, but only The Cateran's holds any hope for the future.

SAM KING

Save De La's Danzas for me

LEE MAVERS and the sunburnt kids — *Mary Scanlon*

HAPPY MONDAYS/THE LA'S/ INSPIRAL CARPETS/ THE POP GUNS
Valencia Barraca Bar

YOU COULD really get to like Juan Santamaria. Every year he flies a clutch of UK journos and flashmen out to Valencia (temperature 100 degrees Fahrenheit and rising) to have a few drinks, meet his extraordinary DJ acquaintance Jorge Albi, have a few more drinks and, for those still capable, attend the Valencia Rock Festival, La Conjura De Las Danzas.

La Conjura De Las Danzas doesn't actually mean anything. Jorge, who thought it up, thinks it means "The Conjure Of The Dances", but then his English isn't too together. It's his obsession not only with British indie music but also, weirdly, the British music press that gives the proceedings their unmistakably surreal edge. As soon as everyone's off the plane, Jorge wants an interview. I was ready for the heat but I didn't expect the Spanish Inquisition.

He's also MC at La Conjura, cautioning the frisky audience to shelve momentarily their Andrea/Tracey preoccupations and give The Pop Guns, pretty girl singer and all, a cracking chance. They're from Brighton and have a slight celebrity factor in drummer Shaun Charman, who used to be in The Wedding Present. In fact, Wendy Morgan's wistful lyrics ('Landslide', 'Someone You Love') have a bit of Gedginess about them, although the three guitar putsch gets a bit wearing after a while – you've really got to be Blue Aeroplanes to carry off that caper. Nevertheless, an auspicious start.

With Shaun Ryder crippled by sunburn – rumour had it someone had Mickey Finn'd his Ambre Solaire with Spry Crisp 'N' Dry – it was left to Inspiral Carpets to be the Official Tour 'Lads'. Good blokes all, they utilised their minimal Spanish vocabulary of "una", "cerveza" and "grande" to heartwarming effect. They hit the stage after Machine Gun, a mediocre English rock combo who came to Valencia some years ago to appear in a talent contest and immediately scored a recording contract.

The Inspirals could do with luck like that; at the moment they can't even blag copies of their first single. But in their 'Inspiral Carpets – Cool As F***' T-shirts they did one of the speediest, jauntiest six song aperitifs imaginable. 'Whiskey' and 'Joe' saw the bar staff pausing respectfully in their nook just underneath the stage to make wow noises in the direction of Clint Boon's Vox. The bowl-headed boy sure can play, and singer Tom Hingley provides a suitably mobile foil.

The La's flew straight in, looked pissed off and, as usual, let their staggering arrogance breeze through their songs. 'I Can't Sleep', the one with the 'Can't Explain' riff but better harmony singing, got a typical "nice one" from bassist John Power, and 'Callin' All', 'Knock Me Down' and 'Son Of A Gun' all moisturised the lips for the much-delayed La's debut album (to date: five producers, all sacked). But Lee Mavers claimed voice loss, or no access to decent lager or something, so the set was curtailed before they could get to the brilliant 'Looking Glass'. I suppose it's this impossibly perfectionist approach that makes them so wonderful. Whatever, they're revered to such an extent here that the new single, 'Timeless Melody', was released in Spain before Britain. Jorge's probably playing it even now.

Happy Mondays wound it up, somewhere around seven in the morning. Never very happy with the proceedings (anyone educated in Valencia's synthetic standards could possibly hazard a guess as to why), they played four songs during which they regularly scowled and snapped at each other. "We've got a f***in' sequencer", drummer Gary was reminded archly after 'Do It Better' was done extremely sloppily. 'Moving In With' wasn't a great improvement, although the groovers and groovesses from local press and TV were visibly enchanted. It was only with 'Mad Cyril' that they started to gel, although Bez's languor and Shaun's sunburn agony (some genius would later suggest wrapping his fried legs in bandages, with the result that all the skin stuck to them; mega-ouch!) dampened Mark's consistently danceworthy guitar.

The night's last number was 'Wrote For Luck'. I'm not sure, but something in the air – the alcohol or the sticky paella we'd all been served for dinner – did a resuscitation number on us and, as a result, this song sounded astonishing and life-enhancing.

Appropriately enough, when Mark was congratulated afterwards, he couldn't even remember playing it. It was that sort of picnic: the real met the surreal, the legal met the dodgy and Happy Mondays remained oblivious throughout. Valencia, you were an experience.

DAVID CAVANAGH